religious and cultural conflicts – for example, between rival Christian sects, between Hindus and Buddhists, and between Platonists and Aristotelians – were fuelled by disagreements about the mind–body problem. Are humans a physical body or a non-physical mind, or perhaps a mind trapped inside a body? In the twenty-first century, the computer network might supercharge the mind–body problem and turn it into a cause for major personal, ideological and political conflicts.

To appreciate the political ramifications of the mind–body problem, let's briefly revisit the history of Christianity. Many of the earliest Christian sects, influenced by Jewish thinking, believed in the Old Testament idea that humans are embodied beings and that the body plays a crucial role in human identity. The book of Genesis said God created humans as physical bodies, and almost all books of the Old Testament assume that humans can exist only as physical bodies. With a few possible exceptions, the Old Testament doesn't mention the possibility of a bodiless existence after death, in heaven or hell. When the ancient Jews fantasised about salvation, they imagined it to mean an earthly kingdom of material bodies. In the time of Jesus, many Jews believed that when the Messiah finally comes, the bodies of the dead would come back to life, here on earth. The Kingdom of God, established by the Messiah, was supposed to be a material kingdom, with trees and stones and flesh-and-blood bodies.[32]

This was also the view of Jesus himself and the first Christians. Jesus promised his followers that soon the Kingdom of God would be built here on earth and they would inhabit it in their material bodies. When Jesus died without fulfilling his promise, his early followers came to believe that he was resurrected *in the flesh* and that when the Kingdom of God finally materialised on earth, they too would be resurrected in the flesh. The church father Tertullian (160–240 CE) wrote that 'the flesh is the very condition on which salvation hinges', and the catechism of the Catholic Church, citing the doctrines adopted at the Second Council of Lyon in 1274, states, 'We believe in God who is creator of the flesh; we believe in the Word made flesh in order to redeem the flesh; we believe in the resurrection of the flesh, the fulfilment of both the creation and the redemption of the flesh … We believe in the true resurrection of this flesh that we now possess.'[33]

Despite such seemingly unequivocal statements, we saw that Saint Paul already had his doubts about the flesh, and by the fourth century CE, under Greek, Manichaean and Persian influences, some Christians had drifted